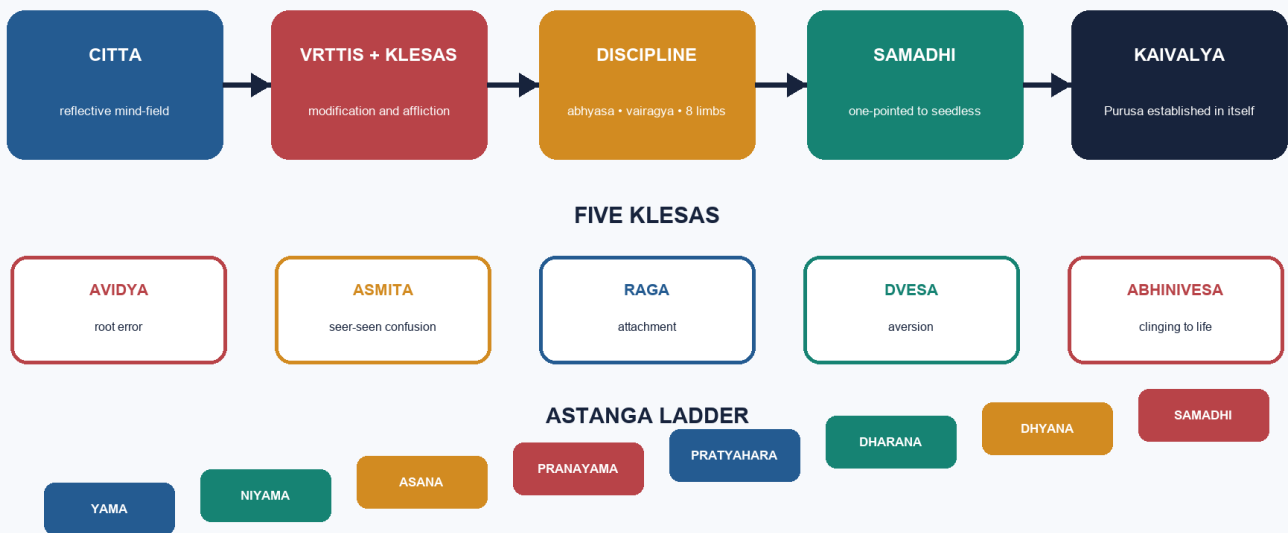


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

YOGA - Syllabus Item 17 (Paper I - Section B)

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

PATANJALA YOGA: FROM CITTA-VRTTI TO KAIVALYA



Isvara = purusa-visesa and privileged aid; viveka-khyati, not divine fusion, completes liberation.

Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

YOGA - Syllabus Item 17 (Paper I - Section B)

12. PYQ ROUTING (2018–2025)

ANALYSIS: **Corpus signal:** 7 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper I corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

Year	Question	Marks	Exact demand
2019	Q7(b)	15 marks	How would Yoga philosophy comprehend the Citta-levels of a Scientist, a God-realized Devotee and a Self-realized Yogi? Justify your answer.
2020	Q5(b)	10 marks	Explain the difference between Samprajñāta Samādhi and Asamprajñāta Samādhi.
2021	Q6(a)	20 marks	Explain with reference to Yoga Philosophy, the nature of kleśas. How does the removal of these lead to kaivalya?
2022	Q5(c)	10 marks	Discuss the nature and different stages of Samādhi as per Pātañjala yoga and examine the role of Īśvara in it.
2023	Q7(c)	15 marks	Explain Citta and its modifications in the philosophy of Yoga. Why does Yoga philosophy prescribe cessation of modifications of Citta? Give reasons in support of your answer.
2024	Q7(b)	15 marks	“So long as there are changes and modifications in citta, the self is reflected therein, and, in the absence of discriminative knowledge, identifies itself with them.” Present an appraisal of Yoga Soteriology in the light of the above statement.
2025	Q7(b)	15 marks	Explain the nature of God and its role in Kaivalya in yoga philosophy.

See the Indian Philosophy PYQ Bank, 2018–2025.

13. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE

13.1 Ten-marker (10 marks)

Open with the exact doctrinal definition.
Name the canonical list/stages.
Give one causal or soteriological explanation.
Add one inter-school distinction or one trap-avoidance line.
Close by answering the directive directly.

Best use-cases: samādhi stages; citta-bhūmis; role of Īśvara; meaning of kaivalya.

13.2 Fifteen-marker (15 marks)

Frame the issue: Yoga as psychology of liberation within Sāṃkhya metaphysics.
Define the central term.
List and explain the canonical sub-types or stages.
Show why the doctrine matters for bondage/liberation.
Contrast with at least one rival school or one common confusion.
Conclude with one evaluative sentence.

Best use-cases: citta-vṛtti-nirodha; nature of God and role in kaivalya; citta and self-reflection.

13.3 Twenty-marker (20 marks)

Intro: locate Yoga as seṣvara-sāṃkhya.
Exposition: define and classify the demanded concept fully.
Mechanism: show the causal chain from ignorance/kleśa to bondage.
Therapy: explain kriyā-yoga / āśāṃga / samādhi / viveka-khyāti as needed.
Comparison: differentiate from Sāṃkhya, Advaita or Nyāya.
Critique and reply: add at least one live objection.
Conclusion: kaivalya as the school's final soteriological meaning.

Best use-case: kleśas and their removal leading to kaivalya.

13.4 Directive-word cues for Yoga answers

- ANALYSIS: The expanded directive decoder is now consolidated in §11E. **DIRECTIVE DECODER** immediately before the PYQ routing section.
- FACT: The original cues are preserved there and expanded into directive-specific structure, examiner demand and closing-verdict formulae.

14. LINK-OUTS

- Metaphysical base: Samkhya.md
- Comparative Vedānta contrasts: Vedanta.md
- Realist contrast on self, God and liberation: Nyaya-Vaisesika.md
- Cross-school self/liberation matrix: Self-and-liberation-across-schools.md
- Cross-school epistemology and Yoga's 3 pramāṇas: Pramana-across-schools.md
- Cross-paper God concepts: Notions-of-God.md
- Cross-paper mystical cognition / samādhi parallels: Religious-Experience.md
- Paper I house constitution: ../00_Master-Framework.md
- PYQ bank: ../PYQ-Indian-Philosophy-2018-2025.md

SOURCES

- Patañjali, *Yoga-sūtra*.
- Vyāsa, *Yoga-bhāṣya*.
- Vācaspati Miśra, *Tattvavaiśārādī*.
- Vijñānabhikṣu, *Yogavārttika*.
- S. Chatterjee and D. Datta, *An Introduction to Indian Philosophy*.
- C.D. Sharma, *A Critical Survey of Indian Philosophy*.
- S. Radhakrishnan, *Indian Philosophy*, Vol. II.

CURRENT LINKAGE - PUBLIC YOGA AND PHILOSOPHICAL YOGA

FACT: Official contemporary anchor: The Ministry of AYUSH's Yoga Mahotsav on **13 March 2026** began the countdown to International Day of Yoga and emphasized public-health protocols, daily practice and broad participation. This is useful as a contemporary opening, but it primarily concerns wellness promotion.

ANALYSIS: Doctrine boundary: Patanjala Yoga is not reducible to exercise or disease-management protocols. Its philosophical core is citta-vrtti-nirodha, removal of klesas, samadhi, viveka-khyati and kaivalya. Public-wellness initiatives illustrate social relevance; they do not establish metaphysical claims about Purusa, Prakriti or Isvara.

Direct local source anchors

- FACT: Chatterjee and Datta, local OCR edition, especially file pages 233-245: citta, five vrttis, citta-bhumis, samadhi, eight limbs and God.
- FACT: C. D. Sharma, local OCR edition, especially file pages 167-172: Patanjala definition, reflection, eight limbs and Isvara.
- FACT: The repository PYQ bank controls wording and marks for the seven solved questions.

PART II - SOLVED PYQs, PRACTICE AND ANSWER TRAINING

Solved PYQ 1 - 2019 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: How would Yoga comprehend the citta-levels of a scientist, a God-realized devotee and a self-realized yogi?

Model solution

Yoga classifies citta into five bhumis: **ksipta** (restless), **mudha** (dull), **viksipta** (intermittently focused), **ekagra** (one-pointed), and **niruddha** (fully restrained).

Person	Citta-level	Justification
Scientist	viksipta	capable of sustained empirical focus, but attention remains outward and fluctuates beyond the chosen task
God-realized devotee	ekagra	mind is one-pointedly established in Isvara and fit for deep meditation
Self-realized yogi	niruddha	all vrttis are restrained and the seer abides in its own nature

The scientist should not automatically be called ekagra merely because of intellectual concentration. Yogic one-pointedness includes freedom from ordinary attachment and a stable inward orientation. The devotee's concentration is supported by Isvara-pranidhana. The self-realized yogi has crossed from concentration on an object to complete restraint.

Verdict: The hierarchy measures not intelligence but the degree of guna-purification and freedom from mental dispersion.

Why this earns marks: It applies all three cases precisely, avoids equating technical focus with yogic realization, and explains the governing criterion.

Solved PYQ 2 - 2020 Q5(b), 10 marks

Question: Distinguish Samprajnata Samadhi and Asamprajnata Samadhi.

Model solution

Samprajnata	Asamprajnata
cognitive absorption with an object	cessation beyond objectifying cognition
supported by prajna and a seed	only residual samskaras may remain
includes vitarka, vicara, ananda and asmita dimensions	reached through supreme dispassion and nirodha
yields truth-bearing insight at higher levels	prepares for nirbija when even seed is exhausted

Samprajnata is not ordinary thought. Citta becomes transparent and takes the object's form with extraordinary clarity. Its detailed samapatti distinctions—savitarka/nirvitarka and savicara/nirvicara—must not be confused mechanically with the fourfold Yoga Sutra 1.17 scheme.

Asamprajnata is not sleep or unconsciousness. Sleep is itself a vrtti supported by absence-cognition, whereas asamprajnata results from disciplined restraint and leaves a transformative nirodha-samskara.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes object, seed, cognition and residual impressions and directly removes the common sleep-confusion.

Solved PYQ 3 - 2021 Q6(a), 20 marks

Question: Explain the nature of klesas and how their removal leads to kaivalya.

Model solution

Klesas are afflictive structures colouring cognition and generating karma. The five are:

1. **Avidya:** mistaking impermanent for permanent, impure for pure, painful for pleasurable and not-self for self.
2. **Asmita:** identification of seer with the seeing instrument.
3. **Raga:** attachment based on remembered pleasure.
4. **Dvesa:** aversion based on remembered pain.
5. **Abhinivesa:** deep clinging to life, present even in the learned.

Avidya is the field of the other four. Klesas may be prasupta, tanu, vicchinna or udara—dormant, attenuated, interrupted or fully active.

avidya → asmita → raga/dvesa → action
→ karmasaya → vipaka → rebirth and suffering

Their removal is graded. **Kriya-yoga**—tapas, svadhyaya and Isvara-pranidhana—attenuates them. Eight-limbed discipline purifies conduct, body, breath, senses and attention. Dhyana burns subtle afflictions; discriminative knowledge destroys avidya's root. When klesas cease, fresh karmic deposits stop, old seeds are exhausted or burnt, and citta no longer produces identification.

Samadhi alone is instrumental unless it matures into **viveka-khyati**, uninterrupted discrimination between Purusa and citta. Para-vairagya prevents attachment even to insight and powers. Dharmamegha-samadhi completes the cessation of binding tendencies; the gunas undergo pratiprasava and Purusa stands in kaivalya.

An objection says Purusa was always free, so removal is unnecessary. Yoga replies that liberation removes misidentification in citta, not an actual impurity in Purusa.

Verdict: Klesa-removal leads to kaivalya by breaking both the cognitive root and karmic reproduction of bondage.

Why this earns marks: It defines all five, gives their states and causal chain, integrates kriya-yoga, astanga, samadhi and viveka, and answers the already-free objection.

Solved PYQ 4 - 2022 Q5(c), 10 marks

Question: Discuss stages of Samadhi and examine the role of Isvara.

Model solution

Patanjala Yoga broadly distinguishes **samprajnata** and **asamprajnata** samadhi. Samprajnata retains cognitive support and is associated with vitarka, vicara, ananda and asmita. The samapatti analysis further distinguishes gross and subtle absorptions with and without conceptual admixture. Nirvicara maturity yields **rtambhara prajna**, truth-bearing insight.

Asamprajnata suspends objectifying cognition while residual samskaras may remain. **Nirbija samadhi** occurs when even the seed sustaining further mental emergence is exhausted. Dharmamegha marks the culminating cloud of virtue and complete dispassion.

Isvara is **purusa-visesa**, eternally untouched by klesa, karma, fruition and latent deposits. Devotion to Isvara, repetition and contemplation of pranava, and surrender reduce obstacles and accelerate samadhi.

Verdict: Isvara is a privileged practical aid and timeless teacher, not the material cause or automatic giver of kaivalya; discriminative knowledge remains decisive.

Why this earns marks: It gives the stage architecture without conflating lists and evaluates Isvara's exact, limited function.

Solved PYQ 5 - 2023 Q7(c), 15 marks

Question: Explain citta and its modifications. Why prescribe cessation of cittavrttis?

Model solution

Citta is the material-subtle internal instrument comprising buddhi, ahamkara and manas. It reflects Purusa and assumes forms corresponding to objects. Its five vrttis are:

Vrtti	Meaning
Pramana	valid cognition
Viparyaya	error
Vikalpa	verbal construction without corresponding object
Nidra	sleep supported by cognition of absence
Smrti	retention and recollection

Each may be klista or aklista. Even valid cognition is a vrtti because it modifies citta and can sustain identification, though aklista cognition helps generate discrimination.

Yoga prescribes nirodha because the seer mistakes reflected mental states for itself. Modification creates samskara; samskara generates further vrtti and karmic continuity. Through abhyasa and vairagya this cycle is restrained:

vrtti → identification → klesa → karma → samskara → further vrtti
nirodha → viveka → non-identification → kaivalya

Nirodha is not destruction of mind or blankness. It is disciplined cessation allowing Purusa to abide in its own nature.

Verdict: Cessation is prescribed not because cognition is intrinsically evil, but because unrestrained modification obscures the distinction between seer and seen.

Why this earns marks: It defines citta, lists all vrttis, explains the samskara loop and gives a non-nihilistic account of nirodha.

Solved PYQ 6 - 2024 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: Appraise Yoga soteriology in light of citta-reflection and self-identification.

Model solution

Yoga accepts the Samkhya dualism of inactive consciousness and active but unconscious citta. Citta is sattva-predominant and transparent; it reflects Purusa like a crystal reflecting a flower. It thereby appears conscious, while Purusa appears to know, act and suffer.

Bondage begins when **asmita** identifies drk-sakti, the seer's power, with darsana-sakti, the seeing instrument. Vrttis become appropriated as "I think," "I desire" and "I suffer." Klesas generate karma, deposits and rebirth.

Yoga's soteriology transforms the reflecting medium:

1. yama-niyama reduce moral disturbance;
2. asana-pranayama stabilize body and vitality;
3. pratyahara withdraws sensory dispersion;
4. dharana-dhyana-samadhi produce one-pointed transparency;
5. viveka-khyati permanently distinguishes Purusa from citta.

Kaivalya does not alter Purusa; it ends misattribution. The gunas cease functioning for that Purusa and return toward their causal ground.

The objection is that reflection presupposes a relation between ontologically separate principles. Mere proximity names rather than explains it. Yoga replies that all change occurs on the citta side; Purusa remains untouched.

Verdict: Yoga offers a coherent therapy of misidentification, though its reflection model inherits Samkhya's unresolved interaction problem.

Why this earns marks: It translates the quotation, traces the complete therapeutic sequence and gives the strongest metaphysical criticism.

Solved PYQ 7 - 2025 Q7(b), 15 marks

Question: Explain the nature of God and its role in Kaivalya in Yoga.

Model solution

Isvara is a **special Purusa** untouched by klesas, karma, karmic fruition and latent impressions. He is eternally free, omniscient in the unsurpassed sense and the timeless teacher of earlier teachers. Pranava is his verbal symbol.

Isvara is not Prakriti, not one liberated Purusa among others, and not straightforwardly the creator-God of Nyaya. Patanjali's primary interest is practical. **Isvara-pranidhana** weakens egoism, creates one-pointed devotion, removes obstacles and offers a direct aid to samadhi.

Kaivalya nevertheless consists in discriminative knowledge between Purusa and Prakriti. God does not absorb the individual, grant union with himself, or replace citta-nirodha. His role is privileged but instrumental:

Isvara-pranidhana → reduced obstacles and ego
→ deeper samadhi → viveka-khyati
→ cessation of guna-purpose → kaivalya

Critics ask why Isvara is needed if the Samkhya ontology and viveka already suffice. Yoga may concede that other routes exist while insisting that devotion is uniquely efficient and that timeless teacherhood grounds the transmission of liberating knowledge.

Verdict: Isvara distinguishes Yoga from nirisvara Samkhya, but kaivalya remains isolation of Purusa through discrimination, not salvation by divine fusion.

Why this earns marks: It defines Isvara precisely, states positive and negative functions, connects devotion to kaivalya and evaluates the redundancy objection.

Integrated MCQ Loop - 24 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
1	Yoga is defined as: A. citta-vrtti-nirodha B. union with creator C. bodily fitness D. ritual action	A	Patanjali defines Yoga as restraint of mental modifications.
2	Citta includes: A. Purusa alone B. buddhi, ahamkara and manas C. gross body only D. five elements	B	It is the operative inner instrument.
3	The scientist in the PYQ is best placed at: A. mudha B. kshipta C. vikshipta D. niruddha	C	Strong but outward and intermittent focus remains vikshipta.
4	Complete restraint corresponds to: A. ekagra B. mudha C. vikshipta D. niruddha	D	Niruddha is fully restrained citta.
5	Root klesa is: A. avidya B. raga C. dvesa D. abhinivesa	A	Other afflictions grow in avidya's field.
6	Confusion of seer and seeing instrument is: A. smrti B. asmita C. nidra D. pramana	B	Asmita identifies Purusa with buddhi/citta.
7	Attachment based on pleasure is: A. abhinivesa B. avidya C. raga D. dvesa	C	Raga follows remembered pleasure.
8	Instinctive clinging to life is: A. asmita B. raga C. dvesa D. abhinivesa	D	It persists even in the learned.
9	Kriya-yoga consists of: A. tapas, svadhyaya, Isvara-pranidhana B. yama, niyama, asana C. dharana, dhyana, samadhi D. pramana, viparyaya, smrti	A	These attenuate klesas and prepare samadhi.
10	The fifth limb is: A. pranayama B. pratyahara C. dharana D. dhyana	B	Withdrawal follows breath regulation.
11	Continuous flow of attention is: A. asana B. dharana C. dhyana D. samyama	C	Dhyana is uninterrupted meditative flow.
12	Combined dharana-dhyana-samadhi is: A. nirodha B. viveka C. kriya-yoga D. samyama	D	Samyama is their integrated application.
13	Valid cognition is called: A. pramana-vrtti B. viparyaya C. vikalpa D. nidra	A	Even truth is a modification of citta.
14	Word-based construction without object is: A. smrti B. vikalpa C. pramana D. samadhi	B	Vikalpa arises from words lacking corresponding fact.
15	Sleep counts as vrtti because: A. it is samadhi B. Purusa sleeps C. absence-cognition leaves a recoltable impression D. all senses act	C	Later recollection indicates a supporting mental mode.
16	Samprajnata samadhi retains: A. no samskara whatsoever B. creator-consciousness C. bodily motion D. cognitive object/support	D	It is absorption with prajna and seed.
17	Truth-bearing insight is: A. rtambhara prajna B. asmita C. viveka only after death D. savitarka	A	It arises from mature nirvicara.
18	Isvara is: A. Prakriti B. purusa-visesa C. material creator D. liberated citta	B	He is eternally untouched special Purusa.
19	Isvara's verbal symbol is: A. Veda B. mahat C. pranava D. akasa	C	Om/pranava is contemplated with its meaning.
20	Kaivalya means: A. union with Brahman B. heavenly enjoyment C. merging into God D. isolation and self-establishment of Purusa	D	It is separation from guna-purpose.
21	Immediate liberating cognition is: A. viveka-khyati B. sensory perception C. testimony alone D. memory	A	Stable discrimination separates seer and seen.

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
22	Dharmamegha samadhi is linked with: A. attachment to powers B. supreme dispassion and final removal of affliction C. ordinary concentration D. sleep	B	It culminates the path when insight itself is not appropriated.
23	Yoga differs from Samkhya chiefly by: A. rejecting Purusa B. denying Prakriti C. adding disciplined praxis and Isvara D. accepting monism	C	It is often called sesvara-Samkhya.
24	Best doctrinal warning: A. Yoga is exercise only B. kaivalya is union C. Isvara creates matter D. public wellness Yoga must not replace Patanjala soteriology	D	Contemporary practice and classical doctrine must be distinguished.

Remedial MCQ Loop - 8 Questions

Q	Question and options	Key	Explanation
25	Ekagra means: A. one-pointed citta B. torpid citta C. fully seedless state D. error	A	It is Yoga-fit concentration but not complete restraint.
26	Which vrtti is recollection? A. nidra B. smrti C. vikalpa D. viparyaya	B	Smrti retains past experience.
27	Klesas in attenuated condition are: A. prasupta B. udara C. tanu D. vicchinna	C	Tanu means thinned through practice.
28	Asamprajnata is not sleep because it: A. contains ordinary dreams B. is caused by fatigue C. lacks discipline D. results from nirodha and transformative samskara	D	Its causal and soteriological structure differs from nidra.
29	First five limbs are generally: A. bahiranga B. antaranga C. samyama D. kaivalya	A	They are external aids relative to the final three.
30	Yoga's Isvara primarily functions as: A. material cause B. aid to concentration and timeless teacher C. karmic sufferer D. universal substance	B	Patanjali's emphasis is practical.
31	Reflection theory says: A. Purusa changes into citta B. citta is self-luminous C. citta appears conscious through Purusa's reflection D. both are identical	C	Citta borrows luminosity without changing Purusa.
32	Best overall verdict: A. Yoga is posture science B. samadhi alone automatically liberates C. God replaces discrimination D. Yoga integrates ethics and psychology, though dualist interaction remains contested	D	This captures its strength and central pressure.

Original Mains Practice 1 - 10 marks

Question: Why does Yoga count valid cognition among the vrttis to be restrained?

Model solution

Pramana presents objects truly, but it still modifies citta and can sustain identification: "I know." Yoga distinguishes epistemic truth from soteriological freedom. Valid cognition may be aklista and assist viveka, yet any object-form is still part of the seen.

The path therefore uses true cognition to remove error and finally relinquishes even the instrument when stable discrimination is achieved—like a thorn removing a thorn.

Verdict: Pramana is not condemned as false; it is transcended because kaivalya requires freedom from all citta-identification.

Why this earns marks: It resolves the apparent paradox and distinguishes truth-value from liberating finality.

Original Mains Practice 2 - 15 marks

Question: Is Astanga Yoga an ethical psychology rather than a sequence of exercises?

Model solution

The eight limbs form a causal architecture. Yama and niyama reduce interpersonal and intrapsychic disturbance. Asana stabilizes embodiment; pranayama regulates vitality and attention; pratyahara breaks sensory compulsion. Dharana, dhyana and samadhi progressively unify cognition.

The limbs therefore transform habits, affects, attention and identity. Without non-violence, truthfulness and non-grasping, concentration may strengthen ego and klesa rather than dissolve them. Without the inner limbs, ethics remains good conduct but does not mature into direct discrimination.

Verdict: Astanga is an ethical psychology completed in meditative epistemology; treating it as bodily exercise severs the very mechanism by which it leads to kaivalya.

Why this earns marks: It explains the functional relation among all limbs and states why ethical preparation is philosophically necessary.

Original Mains Practice 3 - 20 marks

Question: "Isvara is indispensable to Yoga practice but dispensable to Yoga metaphysics." Critically examine.

Model solution

Yoga's metaphysical framework largely follows Samkhya: Purusa, Prakriti, gunas, citta, karma and viveka explain bondage and liberation. Kaivalya occurs through discriminative knowledge, not union with or creation by God. This supports the claim of metaphysical dispensability.

Yet Isvara is more than ornament. As purusa-visesa he represents eternally unobstructed consciousness, grounds timeless teacherhood, supplies pranava as meditative support and makes surrender a powerful antidote to egoism. Patanjali explicitly presents Isvara-pranidhana as a route to samadhi.

The strongest instrumental reading says other means—abhyasa, vairagya and astanga—can also lead to realization, so Isvara is a uniquely efficient optional aid. A stronger theistic reading argues that transmission of liberating knowledge and coordination of Purusa-Prakriti require him; later commentators expand this role.

The redundancy objection remains: if Isvara neither creates Prakriti nor grants liberation, Yoga's distinct theism seems thin. The reply is that practical indispensability need not mean cosmological authorship. A perfect intentional object can reorganize citta without replacing its own effort and insight.

Verdict: The statement is broadly correct but too sharp. Isvara is not constitutive of the material ontology or formal definition of kaivalya, yet he is philosophically significant as exemplar, teacher and privileged technology of de-centering the ego.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes metaphysical, epistemic and practical roles, presents competing readings and reaches a qualified verdict.
